Draft for discussion

Tidewell Cold Chain: entering the Nordic market through a partnership in food service

Market attractiveness, where to play and how to enter

Tidewell Cold Chain Board | 17 November 2026 | Strategy team

Confidential and proprietary. For internal discussion only.

We recommend entering the Nordics in food service through a partner, for €24m over three years

The Nordic market is worth €9.6bn and growing 5.8% a year

- It reaches €12.7bn by 2031
- The two largest incumbents hold 45% of it today

Food service is where we are best placed to win

- It is the most fragmented segment: the top two hold 33%
- Our UK food service customers already ask us to serve their Nordic sites

Partnering scores highest of the three entry routes, at 3.0 out of 4

- Building costs €58m and buying costs €95m
- A partner costs €24m and brings customers from day one

The plan reaches €190m revenue by 2031, about 1.5% of the market

- Break-even in year four
- We ask the Board to approve partner talks and a €2m due diligence budget

1. Market defined as temperature-controlled warehousing and transport in Denmark, Sweden, Norway and Finland.
Source: Nordic Cold Chain Observatory, Market Report 2026 (fictional); Tidewell strategy team analysis. Fictional example.

The Nordic cold chain market is €9.6bn today and grows to €12.7bn by 2031

€9.6bn

Market size, 2026

Four countries; warehousing and transport

5.8%

Growth a year, 2026 to 2031

Driven by food service and pharma

€12.7bn

Market size, 2031

An extra **€3.1bn** of annual demand

45%

Share of the two largest players

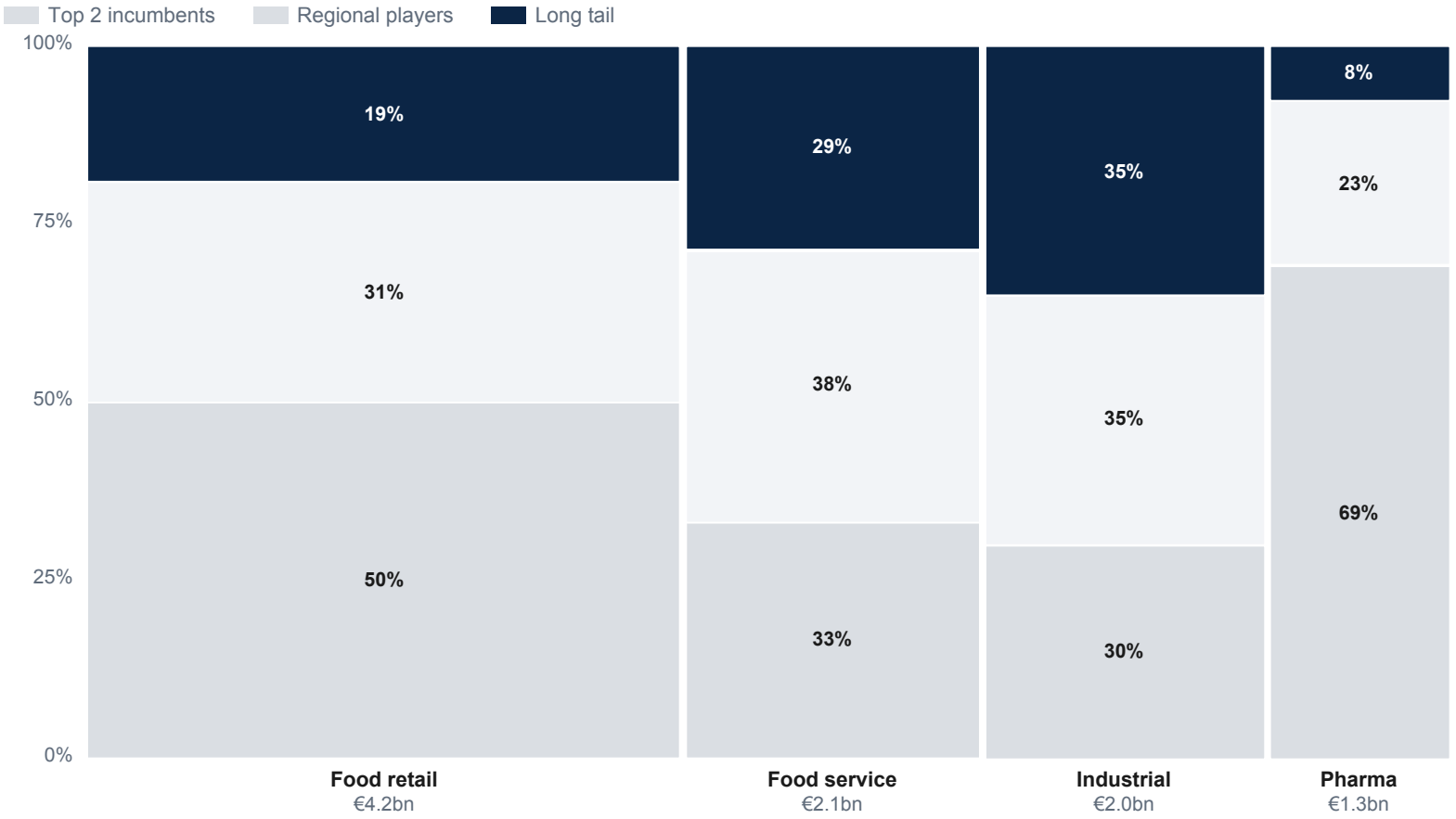
Mostly in food retail and pharma

1. 2031 value is €9.6bn compounded at 5.8% a year for five years.
Source: Nordic Cold Chain Observatory, Market Report 2026 (fictional); Tidewell strategy team analysis. Fictional example.

Food service and industrial customers are the most fragmented, with the two largest players holding a third or less

Nordic cold chain market by customer segment and supplier type

Column width = segment size, €bn, 2026; height = share of segment spend

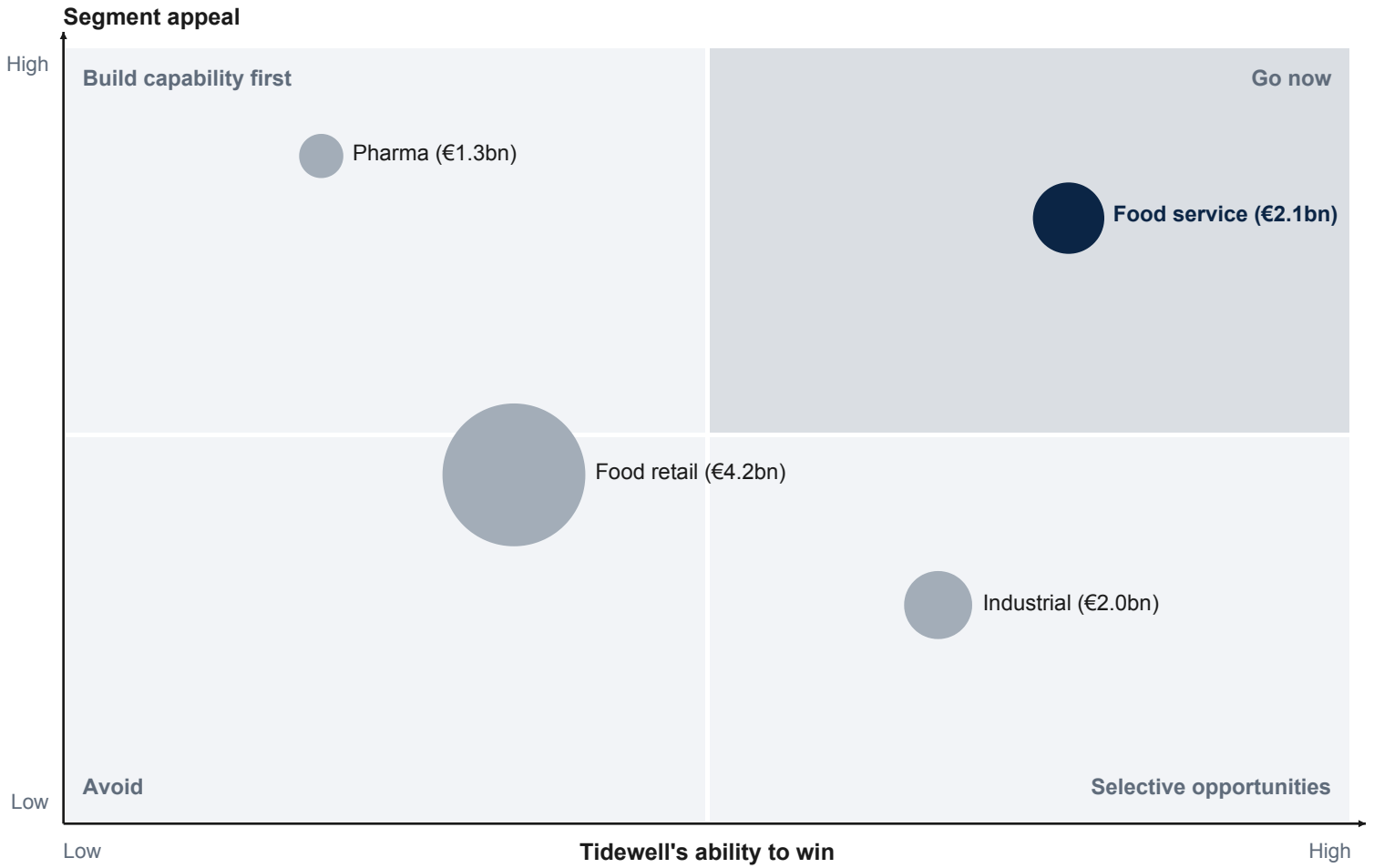


What this shows

1. Top-two share is 33% in food service and 30% in industrial, against 50% in food retail and 69% in pharma.
2. Fragmented segments are easier to enter because no one controls the large contracts.

Source: Nordic Cold Chain Observatory, Market Report 2026 (fictional); Tidewell strategy team analysis. Fictional example.

Food service combines strong growth with our best chance of winning; pharma is attractive but needs licences we lack



Reading the matrix

1. Food service is the only segment in the top right.
2. Pharma needs good distribution practice certification, which takes about 24 months to obtain.

1. Bubble size is 2026 segment size. Scores are the strategy team's judgement from 14 expert interviews and a review of Tidewell's capabilities.
Source: Nordic Cold Chain Observatory, Market Report 2026 (fictional); Tidewell strategy team analysis. Fictional example.

Partnering scores 3.0 out of 4, narrowly ahead of buying at 2.9, and needs a quarter of the capital

Long list (5) → Screened (3) → **Evaluated** → Recommendation

	Weight	**Option A** Build (€58m)	**Option B** Buy (€95m)	**Option C** Partner (€24m)
Speed to revenue	25%	◔	●	◕
Capital required	20%	◑	◔	●
Control of service quality	20%	●	◕	◑
Execution risk	15%	◑	◑	◕
Access to customers	20%	◔	●	◕
Weighted score		**2.0**	**2.9**	**3.0**

○ Weak ◔ ◑ ◕ ● Strong

Rationale

- Partner capital is €24m, a quarter of the €95m to buy
- A partner's depots and drivers serve first customers within 12 months
- We give up some control, so the contract needs service-level penalties
- A call option to buy 51% from year three keeps the acquisition route open

We recommend a partnership with a Danish or Swedish food service distributor, with an option to buy

1. Scores run from 0 (poor) to 4 (strong). Weighted scores: build 1.95 (shown as 2.0), buy 2.90, partner 3.00. Capital is cumulative over three years.
Source: Nordic Cold Chain Observatory, Market Report 2026 (fictional); Tidewell strategy team analysis. Fictional example.

We ask the Board for three decisions to start partner talks in January 2027

#	Decision required	Recommendation and impact	Owner	By
1	**Approve the Nordic food service entry plan**	Approve. Target is €190m revenue by 2031 for €24m cumulative investment	Board	17 Nov
2	**Release €2m for partner due diligence**	Approve. Covers legal, financial and operational review of three shortlisted partners	CFO	30 Nov
3	**Name an executive sponsor for the Nordic launch**	Appoint the Chief Commercial Officer, with a Copenhagen-based country lead hired by March	CEO	15 Dec

Source: Nordic Cold Chain Observatory, Market Report 2026 (fictional); Tidewell strategy team analysis. Fictional example.